Chawla (Eskay to all). Eskay was in Bravo Squadron and hailed from Meerut, an alumnus of St Mary's School. He had three sisters, Lily and Bina older than him and Pammi a few years younger. We both used to be in Class 4 or 5 which is about as low as one can get on the academic ladder, with our cumulative grade point average (CGPA) hovering just above the passing grade. We had the same likes and dislikes, especially in music. We particularly liked a song called 'If I Were a Rich Man', by Chaim Topol from the movie *Fiddler on the Roof*, which had been screened at the Academy. In the lyrics there was a stanza:

I'd build a big, tall house with rooms by the dozen,
Right in the middle of the town.
A fine tin roof with real wooden floors below.
There would be one long staircase just going up,
And one even longer coming down,
And one more leading nowhere, just for show.

Once, in the English term paper, we had to write an essay on our favourite personality. While we chose different personalities, we conspired a bit. I wrote about the staircases saying my third staircase would lead to Eskay's staircase and Eskay wrote that his third staircase would lead to mine. Obviously, Mr Warrier, our English teacher, was not amused and threatened us with relegation for copying. But since we had chosen different personalities, we got away with it. We were equally fortunate on another occasion. This time it was in physics, which even the non-science stream had to do. I had scored a distinction in physics in the school board so this rudimentary physics was super easy for me. Not so for Eskay, who had been an arts student in school. So, we would always sit together during the exams. Once, while solving one of the numerical questions, I

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